

Couch to 5K — 2026

Orientation: 31 May 2026 · BR Community Run
Programme: 1 June – 20 August 2026 · 12 Weeks
Race Day: 23 August 2026 · 5K Parkrun

OUR INITIATIVE

This programme is an initiative of the **Bengaluru Runners Women's Initiative**. While open to all, its core purpose is to give women **a safe and supportive space** to explore long-distance running — to make physical activity a lifestyle habit and to build a community of women who encourage and celebrate each other at every step. **Performance is never the point. Participation and joy are.**

PROGRAMME AT A GLANCE

DURATION 12 Weeks 1 June to 20 August 2026 Orientation: 31 May	SESSIONS PER WEEK 3 Sessions Tue & Thu — solo Sunday — coach-led	TARGET PARTICIPANT Absolute Beginner No prior running experience. Zero fitness base assumed.	RACE DAY GOAL Complete 5K 23 August 2026 Finish line — no time target.
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THE 12-WEEK ARC — MILESTONES TO CELEBRATE

PHASE	WEEKS	WHAT HAPPENS
Foundation	Wks 1–3	Run / walk intervals. Primary goal is tendon and ligament conditioning, not just fitness. First 3-min continuous run is a milestone worth celebrating. ★
Building Blocks	Wks 4–6	Walk breaks shrink. First 5-min then 8-min continuous runs. Week 5 Group: first 10-minute continuous block. ★
Running Emerges	Wks 7–9	Continuous runs build from 25 to 35 minutes. This is where participants stop dreading running and begin to enjoy it.
5K Ready	Wks 10–11	Distance tracked for the first time. Parkrun simulation in Week 10. Week 11 Group: 40 minutes continuous — the longest run of the programme. ★★
Taper	Wk 12	Volume reduces. Legs rest. Race-day logistics briefed. The work is done — trust it.
Race Day	23 Aug	5K Parkrun. Every participant who crosses the finish line wins. The clock is irrelevant.

YOUR ROLE AS COACH / VOLUNTEER

01

Keep it Simple

Absolute novices, zero running background. Plain language, clear instructions, no jargon. If a runner looks confused, simplify further — never assume prior knowledge.

02

Celebrate the Process

Every week has its own milestone. Acknowledge it every Sunday. A runner completing Week 3 has done something most people only talk about. That deserves recognition.

03

Consistency Over Performance

Intentionally moderate programme — caution first, speed next. Your job is to keep them showing up every week. Showing up consistently is the performance.

COACHING BEHAVIOURS

- If a participant wants to quit, **do not argue — listen first**. Ask what is hard. Often it is one difficult session, not the programme. Offer to repeat the week before dropping out entirely.
- **Never compare runners** to each other in pace, distance, or effort. Every body is different. Every start line is different. Comparison kills motivation faster than tired legs ever will.
- **Arrive early on Sundays**. Warm-up drills begin before the run block. The Sunday session is the most important of the week — it sets the tone for solo sessions that follow.
- All volunteers should have **basic first-aid knowledge** — how to respond to a fall, a sprain, or a runner showing signs of distress. Know where the nearest medical support is at every venue.
- Repeat the pace rule every Sunday: **if a runner cannot speak a full sentence mid-run, they are going too fast**. Slow down, always.
- When a runner goes quiet or misses sessions, **reach out — do not wait**. The ones who stop responding are the ones who need the call most.

SESSION STRUCTURE

Tuesday & Thursday — Solo Sessions

Participants train independently. Each session is self-guided: pre-run warm-up, run block, strength or mobility work, and cool-down stretches. All routines are taught on Orientation Day (31 May) so participants arrive on 2 June already knowing the full structure.

Sunday — Coach-Led Group Session

The heart of the programme. Each Sunday includes a named form drill, the week's peak run challenge, a coach interaction moment (talking test, landmark game, group debrief), and a guided strength block. This is where community is built. Every runner should leave feeling more capable than when they arrived.

MISSED SESSIONS POLICY

- **Missed one session** — carry on to the next session as planned.
- **Missed an entire week** — repeat that week in full before progressing.
- **Feeling unwell or in pain** — rest is correct. Running through pain is never the answer at this stage.

SAFETY PROTOCOLS

STOP IMMEDIATELY

Reinforce with participants every week

- Sharp or worsening joint pain — not normal effort burn, but pain that feels wrong
- Chest tightness or breathing difficulty beyond normal exertion
- Dizziness, lightheadedness, or feeling close to fainting
- Pain that gets progressively worse as the run continues
- When in doubt, stop. There is always another session. Act on every serious symptom.

HEAT & HUMIDITY

Bangalore monsoon — June to August

- Heat exhaustion signs: sweating suddenly stopping, weakness, nausea, confusion — shade and hydrate immediately
- Brief participants to arrive pre-hydrated, not just drink during sessions
- Recommend 6–7 AM for solo runs — heat and rain build through the day
- On heavy monsoon days, treadmill is a full substitute for any session
- Avoid mossy tiles and waterlogged paths — ankle sprains are the most common monsoon injury

BEFORE THEY BEGIN

Onboarding checks — Orientation Day, 31 May

- Participants with heart conditions, recent surgery, or ongoing medication should complete a **PAR-Q** (Physical Activity Readiness Questionnaire)
- Check footwear on Day 1 — sandals and canvas shoes are a preventable injury risk. A basic running shoe is non-negotiable.
- Encourage all participants to inform a family member of the programme and share Sunday session venue weekly

SOLO RUN SAFETY

Tuesday & Thursday — women's safety guidelines

- **Share live location** with a trusted contact for the full run duration — an active share, not just a message saying "going running"
- **One earbud out at all times** — full headphones eliminate situational awareness on shared paths and roads
- Stick to **familiar, well-lit, populated routes** — not the time to explore new areas or shortcuts
- Carry the **phone on the body** at all times — not in a bag left at a bench while stretching
- Inform a family member of the **intended route and expected return time** before every solo session
- If something feels unsafe mid-run, **trust that instinct and stop**. No training session overrides safety.

PROGRAMME COORDINATOR & TEAM CONTACTS

TO BE COMPLETED BEFORE DISTRIBUTING THIS BRIEF

LEAD COORDINATOR

CONTACT NUMBER

VOLUNTEER LEAD

CONTACT NUMBER

MEDICAL / FIRST AID CONTACT

CONTACT NUMBER

COACH & VOLUNTEER WHATSAPP GROUP

KEY PROGRAMME DATES

DATE	MILESTONE
31 May 2026	Orientation Day · BR Community Run · Routines taught
1 June 2026	Programme begins · First solo sessions (Tue/Thu)
5 July 2026	★ Wk 5 Sunday · First 10-min continuous block
2 August 2026	★ Wk 9 Sunday · 35 min continuous run
9 August 2026	Wk 10 Sunday · Parkrun simulation · Mock race
16 August 2026	★★ Wk 11 Sunday · 40 min continuous — time on feet
18–20 Aug 2026	Taper week · Two easy sessions · Race briefing
23 August 2026	★★★ Race Day · 5K Parkrun · Every finisher wins

EMERGENCY QUICK REFERENCE

SITUATION	ACTION
Runner collapses	Do not move. Call emergency services. Alert medical contact. Stay with them.
Chest pain or tightness	Stop immediately. Sit in shade. Call emergency services. Do not leave them alone.
Ankle sprain or fall	Stop all activity. RICE — Rest, Ice, Compression, Elevation. Contact medical lead. Do not encourage walking it off.
Heat exhaustion	Move to shade immediately. Cool with water. Small sips of fluid. If no improvement in 15 minutes, call emergency services.
Runner doesn't return	Call them. If no response within 20 min of expected return, contact family member and programme coordinator.
Distressed runner	End their session. Stay with them. Inform coordinator. Never leave a distressed participant alone at any venue.